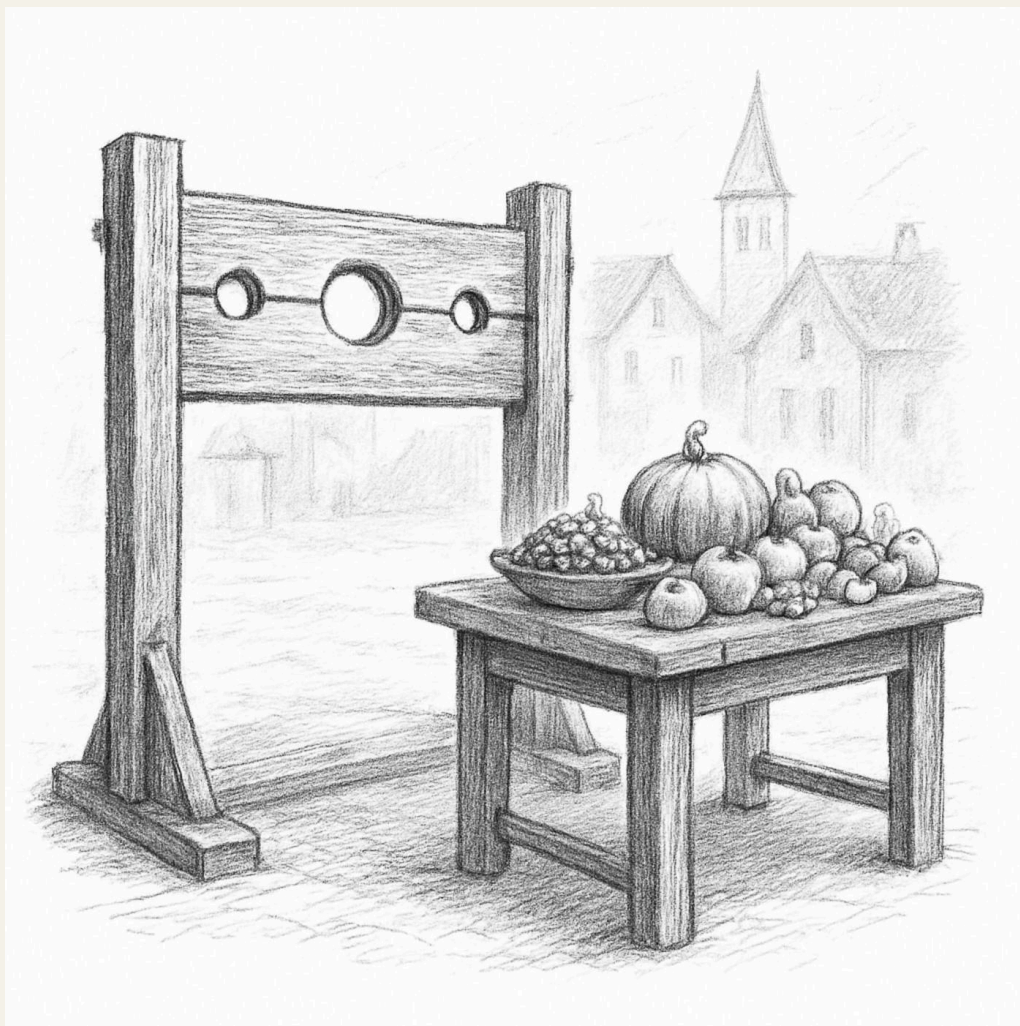


Mercy



A town stock is ready for a guilty person. Beside it, the table holds good fruit, not rotten produce to throw. The sentence was real. The gift is real too.

Before you gather

- Read Day 3, Mercy, in **The Visual Gospel**. Do not reteach the devotional.
- Read Jonah 4:1–2, 10–11 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

When did you brace for a consequence and get kindness instead?

Leader. One sentence. Then open Jonah 4. Mercy in the text is God's, not a warm memory. Do not turn the icebreaker into a journal. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Mercy does not pretend the guilty person deserved a prize. God withholds the judgment sinners earned, and He does it through Christ.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Mercy is God's compassionate withholding of deserved judgment and His tender action toward helpless sinners. It is God's desire to relieve the consequences of sin in those who deserve condemnation through Christ's sacrifice.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek eleos — mercy, kindness, goodwill toward the afflicted.

MEMORY VERSE · 1 PETER 1:3

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead.

Read day 3 of **The Visual Gospel** before you teach it. The drawing and the personal questions are there.

Together, open the flashcard for Mercy. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Jonah 4:1–2, 10–11

Jonah can quote mercy and still hate it. Stay in Jonah 4. He wanted judgment for Nineveh and mercy for himself. Ask what the text says. That instinct is still in the room. Do not reteach the journal.

But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was angry. And he prayed to the LORD and said, "O LORD, is not this what I said when I was yet in my country? That is why I made haste to flee to Tarshish; for I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love, and relenting from disaster." And the LORD said, "You pity the plant, for which you did not labor, nor did you make it grow... And should not I pity Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also much cattle?"

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Jonah can quote God's mercy perfectly. What is his actual problem with it? CORE

Leader. He knew the Lord is gracious, merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love, and that is why he fled. He wants mercy for himself and disaster for Nineveh. Right words. Wrong heart.

2. God compares Nineveh to the plant Jonah pitied. What is He saying about the people Jonah had written off?

Leader. Jonah grieved a plant he did not make. God pitied a city of more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also the cattle. Mercy sees people, not a category to punish.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Peter 1:3 says that by His great mercy God caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ. What did mercy do besides cancel a penalty?

Leader. Mercy caused new birth. The hope is living because Jesus rose. Mercy is not God looking the other way. It is God acting through the cross and the resurrection.

4. James 2:13 says mercy triumphs over judgment. How can we show mercy without pretending sin is small? CORE

Leader. The stocks stay in the picture. The sentence was real. Mercy withholds it because Christ bore it. Mercy that denies guilt is sentiment. Judgment with no Savior is not the gospel. Both stay.

5. Who is a Nineveh you quietly hope will get what is coming? You do not have to say the name. What would pity look like toward them this week?

Leader. A prayer, a meal, a held tongue, a refused insult. Not 'be nicer.' They still need to hear that mercy has a name. Jesus bore the judgment.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Mercy is God withholding the judgment sinners earned, because Jesus bore it.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Withhold the payback you want to give someone far from Jesus. Then say mercy is God not giving the judgment we earned, because Jesus took it on the cross.

Leader. Mercy is not pretending a wrong never happened. It is refusing to finish them, and naming Christ. Do not let the group pick someone already in the church. A kindness that never names Jesus is not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord, thank You that You are merciful and slow to anger, and that You pitied us.
2. Forgive the Jonah in us: mercy for me, and payback for them.
3. Make us merciful in one concrete way this week, and give us courage to name Jesus.

Before you stumble

If they ask how mercy differs from grace, say it in one sentence and move on. Mercy withholds the judgment we deserve. Grace gives the gift we could never earn. Next week is grace. Do not preview it. If someone says mercy means sin does not matter, correct it. The guilty are not cleared by denial. They are spared by Christ.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask where students hear 'you get what you deserve' treated as the highest justice. Then ask if they want God to run the world only that way, including toward them. Read Jonah 4:2. The answer is God's character, not their mood.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 6:35-36. Jesus tells His disciples to be merciful as the Father is merciful, including toward the ungrateful. Read it only if the Jonah conversation is still thin.

